nesting ground for the Indian skimmer, a bird also known as the Indian scissors-bill, as well as the famous gharial, the former NBWL member says sand mining drastically reduces the flow of water in the river, endangering ecological viability, besides causing river bank erosion.

The Rajasthan government, which administers its side of the sanctuary on the west of MP's Morena and Sheopur districts, and the UP government which administers the eastern leg, have made no proposal for denotification even though illegal mining affects all three states. Meanwhile, on June 3, a bench of the Supreme Court reiterated that no mining activity is allowed in a sanctuary or a national park. It also said that the February 2011 notification on activities allowed and proscribed within the 1 km eco-sensitive zone around sanctuaries and national parks must be adhered to.

SAND MINING WILL REDUCE ECOLOGICAL VIABILITY OF THE CHAMBAL RIVER, WARN ECOLOGISTS

Besides parts of the National Chambal Sanctuary, the MP government has also proposed denotification of parts of the Sailana and Sardarpur sanctuaries that are home to the Lesser Florican. The process of denotification has been completed for the entire Karera Sanctuary in Shivpuri district, which was notified in the 1980s for protecting the Great Indian Bustard. It remains to be seen whether the rationale of addressing illegal mining by denotifying parts of the National Chambal Sanctuary passes muster with the NBWL. ■

AIADMK

EPS SEIZES THE DAY

By Amarnath K. Menon



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Perhaps the All-India Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam has finally laid J. Jayalalithaa's ghost to rest. Even in death, *puratchi thalaivi* had remained larger than life, continuing to be the 'eternal general secretary' of the party nearly six years after her demise on December 5, 2016. That changed on July 11 when the AIADMK general council did away with the principle of dual leadership and elected the 68-year-old E. Palaniswami (EPS) as interim general secretary. The former chief minister checkmated both rival contender O. Paneerselvam (OPS) as well as Jayalalithaa aide V. Sasikala to emerge as the sole inheritor of the AIADMK legacy at a time when the party is out of power and has only 66 MLAs in the 234-member assembly, and ally BJP is seen as the more effective Opposition in the state.

Neither OPS's last-minute attempt to have the courts to intervene, nor violent clashes at MGR Maaligai, the party headquarters in Chennai, could stop the inevitable, as the 71-year-old ex-CM and a few others were shown the door. Sasikala, who has been trying to make a comeback since her release in 2021, was neutralised through an amendment in the party constitution (see *A New AIADMK*). Both declared the general council meeting illegal. OPS's attempts to stall it via the courts came to an end at 9 am on July 11, when Justice Krishnan Ramasamy of the Madras High Court said the will of the people has to prevail in a democracy and that courts cannot interfere. If anyone was still aggrieved, they could file a civil suit later, he ruled. Frustrated, OPS and his men stormed MGR Maaligai, squatted there and allegedly made off with computers and digital records. The high drama ended only after the police and other authorities arrived to seal the premises.

EPS, on his part, alleged that OPS employed anti-social elements and colluded with the ruling Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) to create unrest outside the party headquarters. "He (OPS) unleashed violence and took away party property in league with the DMK government. The police did not provide security despite our requests," he said. The DMK dismissed the charge, saying it could not be bothered about the affairs of the Opposition party. Litigation to gain possession of the party HQ may now deepen.

EPS has secured himself for the moment. AIADMK MLAs and district secretaries have no choice but to back him, for the end of AIADMK will bring the curtains down on their political future too. The next assembly poll is not due till 2024. But while OPS may have lost the current skirmish, he is determined to win the war. He claims his expulsion is illegal and he will challenge it in court. He also wants to test his strength among the cadre. "I have been elected by 1.5 crore cadres of our party. I will meet them and seek justice," he says.

Waging another war is Amma confidante Sasikala whose assumption that the AIADMK mantle would seamlessly pass to her after Jaya's death was proved wrong. Ironically, it was OPS who triggered the mutiny against Sasikala following her conviction in 2017, and joined hands with EPS to enable her ouster from the party. Following the end of her prison term, Sasikala has been touring the state